Document Control

Title

Pre-operative eye drops for cataract patients
Standard Operating Procedure

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Consulted with the following stakeholders:

- Karl Whittaker – Ophthalmology Consultant
- Pharmacy
- Head of Learning & Development
- Health & Safety Advisor
- Infection control

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1. Purpose

The Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) has been written to:

- Identify the procedure for the assessment and delivery of basic eye-care giving drops within a ward setting.
- Minimize risks of cross infection between patients when re-using single use eye drops.
- Improve personal care for the patient and reduce the risks associated with poor care.

2. Scope

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) relates to the following staff groups who may be involved in the assessment and delivery of eye drops on the wards:

- Registered nurses
- Support workers Band 3 – with eye drop competent training

Registered nurses, medical staff and those trained in giving eye drops by the Ophthalmology Department should assess the patients need for eye-care and make an informed decision as to whether a referral to the Ophthalmology department is necessary.

3. Location

This Standard Operating Procedure giving patients eye drops can be implemented in all clinical areas where competent staff are available to undertake this role.

Staff undertaking this procedure must be able to demonstrate continued competence as per the organisations policy on assessing and maintaining competence.

4. Equipment

- Kidney dish
- Eye drops
- Tissue
- Patient identifier sticker

5. Procedure

- Prepare a separate kidney dish for each patient and place the patients name and which eye needs the drops on each dish.

- Place the drops required as written on the prescription chart into the kidney dish, with a tissue. Check the drops and dates are correct.

- To ensure the patient is correctly identified check against the medical records, wristband and check for any allergies to medication/eye drops. To help reduce risk of adverse reactions.

- Ensure the patient has been marked with a marker pen above the eye brow after agreement with the patient and corresponds with the theatre list and notes.

- Once the patient checks have been performed and are correct, staff must wash and dry hands to reduce the risk of infection.

- Ensure the patient is positioned comfortably and explain to the patient why they need the eye drops prior to surgery in order to gain their cooperation, obtain consent and alleviate anxiety.

- Ensure that clean tissues are within reach for the patient to use to reduce cross infection to the nose or other eye.

- Ask the patient to look up to the ceiling gently extending the neck if possible. Pull the lower lid down gently to create a 'well', which helps to prevent blinking, which can occur if the drop falls onto the cornea.

- Instil one drop into lower fornix without touching the eye, the lids or lashes or your own fingers with the tip of the vial or bottle. If contact has occurred replace with a new vial to ensure a non-touch and sterile procedure has been followed to reduce the possibility of infections.

- After each drop replace the cap on vial or bottle immediately. When re-capping the vial/bottle ensure a non-touch technique is used and place back into the labelled dish ready to re-use as prescribed. Non-touch contact will prevent cross infection.

- Advise the patient to relax neck and gently close the eye avoiding the tendency to squeeze the eye closed. This will allow time for absorption of the drops.

- Write the date, time and sign the prescription chart. Repeat the process as prescribed.

6. References

- Ring, L. Okoro, M, (2012) A handbook of Ophthalmic Nursing Standards and Procedures, M&K publishing, Keswick.